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CSU plans to revise English test mandate for international applicants

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The California State University system currently requires undergraduate applicants whose schooling was in a language other than English to take the Test of English as a Foreign Language to prove their proficiency in the language. This may soon change.

At the CSU Board of Trustees meeting Tuesday, Vice Chancellor Dilcie Perez proposed an amendment to the university's admissions policy that would replace the TOEFL requirement with "multiple approved measures" to demonstrate English proficiency. This, she said, would modernize the requirement and reduce barriers like test availability and related costs.

"The amendment would neither eliminate nor lower the English language proficiency requirement," Perez said. "Applicants would still need to demonstrate proficiency sufficient to participate successfully in and benefit from university-level study."

The proposal, which mostly affects international applicants, will be voted on by 25-member board at its next meeting in November.

About 2.5% of the CSU's more than 470,000 students come from outside the U.S. — which has steadily declined over the last decade. The CSU, like the University of California, maintains an English proficiency requirement because most classes are taught in English. Applicants whose native language is not English or who have not had at least three years of secondary education taught in English must demonstrate their ability to read, write and speak the language.

At the CSU, the only present option to prove proficiency is to provide a TOEFL score. For undergraduate programs, applicants require a minimum score of 500 on the paper-based exam or a score of 61 on the internet version. Per policy, individual campuses can create exceptions for applicants who are able to provide other "convincing evidence" of English competence. They also have the authority to prescribe higher minimum TOEFL scores based on local factors like the availability of instruction in English as a second language and student enrollment demand.

The TOEFL can be taken year-round at centers around the world. It is administered by ETS, a New Jersey-based educational testing organization. According to ETS, the TOEFL is recognized by more than 13,500 institutions across 160 countries. The registration fee depends on the testing location. It can cost anywhere from $170 in Ukraine and Nigeria to $475 in Switzerland.

CSU officials say the TOEFL requirement is outdated and no longer reflects the range of assessments and methods currently used to evaluate English proficiency. In the UC system, for example, international applicants can demonstrate English proficiency by meeting a minimum score in an Advanced Placement or International Baccalaureate exam in high school. Applicants can also take the International English Language Testing System exam, TOEFL, Duolingo English Test, ACT or SAT, among other options.

If the proposal goes through, undergraduate applicants to the CSU will be able to choose from many of the same options, officials said. That includes the TOEFL.

CSU officials supporting the amendment said the TOEFL creates "unnecessary regulatory limitations" and barriers for applicants. Individual campuses will still have the discretion, per the proposed change, to prescribe higher minimum scores than the university system.

The CSU's TOEFL move comes as the UC system debates whether to reinstate a standardized testing requirement in its undergraduate admissions policy for all applicants.

The issue first surfaced when a group of professors drew attention to what they called a widening gap in mathematics ability in their classrooms a few months ago. They blamed the problem on the removal of the SAT/ACT requirement from the admissions process in 2020. Others, however, argued that the issue had larger roots and bringing back standardized testing would disadvantage students from marginalized communities. Now, the university is expected to make a decision by June.

Supreme Court upholds data search for noncitizens on voter rolls

BY DAVID G. SAVAGE
Los Angeles Times

WASHINGTON

The Supreme Court on Friday upheld President Donald Trump's expanded use of government data to spot noncitizens who are registered to vote.

The justices granted an emergency appeal from Trump's lawyers and set aside a judge's order that blocked use of this data on the grounds it was error-prone, particularly for naturalized citizens.

Justices Ketanji Brown Jackson, Sonia Sotomayor and Elena Kagan dissented.

The decision will aid states that seek to scrub their voter rolls and remove those who are not citizens.

Several Republican-led states including Texas and Florida supported the administration's appeal.

The use of the new database "allowed Texas to more efficiently, promptly, and economically ensure the accuracy of its voter rolls," the state said. It was "able to run its entire list of 18 million voters" through the expanded system of checks "in bulk and for no cost."

It's not clear the decision will have much impact in California and other Democratic-led states. It is likely to have a limited impact in the month ahead because the law forbids states from purging their voter rolls in the 90 days before an election.

The court, in an unsigned opinion, said the law supported use of the data.

"The federal Government has an obligation to respond to requests from state and local election officials seeking to verify the citizenship of voters," the court said. "The order below prevents the federal government from using the program it believes is best suited to the task."

The administration said the Department of Homeland Security can respond to more than 1 million requests per day to check if a person appears to be a citizen or not based on Social Security records and other data files.

If not, state or county election officials may require these suspect voters to furnish proof of their citizenship.

However, states and local election boards are not required to conduct these searches. The administration also said its data reports are not final proof of citizenship.

Upholding these data searches "would not require states, candidates, parties, or voters to do anything," Solicitor Gen. D. John Sauer told the court. "It would simply make available to states additional information. ... States that wish to use that information in the course of ensuring that only eligible citizens cast ballots this November should be free to do so."

In dissent, Jackson said the court's order creates the "risk that states might cancel the voter registrations of at least some recently naturalized citizens or force such persons to provide proof of citizenship before voting."

The new system of voter checks is based on the 40-year-old Systematic Alien Verification for Entitlements, or SAVE, that was created by Congress. Then, the goal was to check if applicants were entitled to receive federal benefits.

Last year, Trump issued an executive order directing Homeland Security to expand the reach of SAVE to provide states "access to appropriate systems for verifying the citizenship or immigration status of individuals registering to vote or who are already registered to vote."

It is a federal crime for noncitizens to register and vote.

Trump has long maintained that noncitizens are voting, but he has had little evidence to support that claim.

Voting rights advocates sued, contending the new "mass verification" system was not authorized by Congress and relied on data that are protected as private under the law.

Hilton, Becerra's California state voter guide statements are blank. It's by design

BY BEN PAVIOUR
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California's 176-page voter guide is dense with ballot measure legalese, policy debates and obscure candidates for statewide office.

But as the guides have begun showing up in voters' mailboxes, some have noted it's missing some seemingly important information: candidate statements from the two candidates for governor.

While some social media users suggested the move showed both candidates weren't taking the campaign seriously, there's another explanation.

To be eligible for the statements, statewide candidates must agree to voluntary spending limits. Both Becerra and Hilton candidates declined to agree to the roughly $19.6 million cap in general election spending.

The same applies to Attorney General Rob Bonta, a Democratic incumbent who refused a spending threshold of $11.8 million in his reelection campaign.

That refusal is not new. While Republican gubernatorial hopefuls have occasionally agreed to the voluntary limits, the last Democratic candidate to do so was former Gov. Grey Davis in 2002.

Christian Grose, a political science professor at the University of Southern California, said the campaigns recognized that additional campaign funding went farther in reaching voters than the guide itself. Grose said it might be worth rethinking the idea of excluding candidates or significantly raising the spending limits.

"If you're trying to inform the public via voter guide, not having candidates involved isn't that helpful," Grose said.

The system dates back to Proposition 34, a ballot measure voters passed in 2000 that replaced a similar, 1996 measure that had become bogged down in a legal fight.

Prop. 34 set up limits on how much donors could give candidates and established the voluntary spending limits. Initially the proposition set a limit of $10 million for gubernatorial general election spending; the Fair Political Practices Commission adjusts the amount every two years based on inflation.

Candidates who want to appear in the voter guide still have to pay to do so, at a rate that varies based on the office they're seeking.

Newsom signs bills creating security protections for religious worshipers

BY LIA RUSSELL
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California now bans people from protesting, harassing or blocking people exiting or entering a religious facility within a certain radius, after Gov. Gavin Newsom signed two bills Friday that shore up state protections for religious worshipers.

Assembly Bill 2664 makes it illegal for a protestor who is within 100 feet of a religious facility to approach someone who is within eight feet of an entrance or exit to petition or protest the person or intentionally harass, obstruct, threaten or intimidate them. The other bill Newsom signed, Assembly Bill 1836, expands the availability of state security grants to offsite celebrations like cultural and religious festivals, marches and LGBTQ pride events.

Newsom signed AB 2264 on Friday at the Wilshire Boulevard Temple in Los Angeles, where police arrested two people last December at a demonstration outside the synagogue because the temple was hosting a private event with a speaker from Elbit Systems, the Israeli military's largest defense contractor. The protesters were criticizing Elbit for manufacturing "weapons and technology that Israel uses against Palestinian civilians" and its contracts with U.S. border security agencies.

"Every Californian should be able to walk into a synagogue, church, mosque or other house of worship without fear," Newsom said. "California is continuing to protect these organizations and the people they serve, and we're strengthening that work from the front door to expanding security resources to community events statewide."

AB 2264's sponsor, Assemblymember Rebecca Bauer-Kahan, D-Orinda, thanked Newsom for creating a "safe bubble zone," noting that antisemitism has risen in recent years.

"For too long, too many people have been asked to accept fear as part of practicing their faith," she said. "As a Jewish woman and a mother, I know this is not abstract — one in four Jewish Americans now says they do not feel safe attending Jewish institutions."

Newsom's signing of AB 1836 sent a "clear message that Californians of all faiths and backgrounds should be able to gather, worship and celebrate without fear," according to its sponsor, Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino. "Under Governor Newsom's leadership, California has been at the forefront of the fight against hate, and we are deeply grateful to him for signing this important new law."

The Legislative Jewish caucus, which Gabriel chairs and Bauer-Kahan is a member of, supported both bills, along with the Legislative LGBTQ caucus.

"AB 1836 strengthens California's commitment to protecting organizations and communities that too often face threats simply because of who they are or who they serve," said Assemblymember Chris Ward, D-San Diego, who chairs the LGBTQ caucus. "With Governor Newsom signing AB 1836, California is ensuring our LGBTQ+, Jewish, and other communities targeted by hate have the resources they need to gather safely and without fear."

NY and NJ declare states of emergency for Nor'easter

Reuters

NEW YORK

A strong nor'easter brought flooding, powerful wind gusts, heavy rain and rip currents to areas along the East Coast from Washington, D.C., to Maine over the weekend.

The governors of New York and New Jersey declared states of emergency in counties expected to see the worst of the storm, including New York City.

"Take this storm seriously," New York Governor Kathy Hochul said on X.

Shows in New York City and Massachusetts where Ed Sheeran, Alicia Keys and Lenny Kravitz were scheduled to perform before tens of thousands of attendees were canceled due to weather.

The Federal Aviation Administration expected that flights at all three major New York City-area airports could be disrupted by strong winds.

American Airlines , JetBlue and United Airlines waived change fees for eligible flights, encouraging customers to postpone travel between Friday and Sunday in the Northeast.

The National Weather Service said winds of up to 55 miles per hour (88.5 km/h) in some areas could make driving difficult.

New York City officials warned of possible basement flooding, power outages and travel disruptions.

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